



ALL LEVELS · ONE SESSION

Prompt Engineering: The Whole Journey

A fast crash course through every move — from a one-line ask to a designed, reusable workflow. Twelve techniques, one real example, one session.



THE JOURNEY

All four stages — in one session

1

STAGE 1

Asking

One-line requests, hit or miss. Where everyone starts.



2

STAGE 2 · COMPOSE

Composing

CO-STAR + the Refine loop — strong prompts on purpose.



3

STAGE 3 · DIRECT

Directing

Examples, reasoning, structure, your own documents, diagnosis.



4

STAGE 4 · DESIGN

Designing

Chaining, templates, context, evaluation, guardrails.



LEARNING OBJECTIVES

By the end of this session, you will be able to:

1

Compose a strong prompt

Build it with CO-STAR, then improve it in one refine follow-up.

2

Direct the model

Lock format with examples, ask for reasoning first, structure long prompts, ground it in your documents, diagnose misses.

3

Design reusable workflows

Chain the steps, share a template, right-size the context, and test what “good” means.

4

Do all of it safely

Grounded, cited, verified — and member data never goes in.



STAGE 1 · ASKING

Where everyone starts — and our example

The model isn't Google, and it can't read your mind — it only knows what you tell it. Type one line and hope — “summarize this feedback” — and you get something vague back, because you gave it almost nothing.

Everything in this session is one habit: telling it what only you know. We'll practice on one real pile of member feedback the entire session.

OUR RUNNING EXAMPLE

Last weekend's survey — about 30 comments. Five of them:

“Waited 22 min at checkout — only 3 lanes open.”

“Rotisserie chicken is always fresh!”

“The app froze when I clipped the gas coupon.”

“Gas pump 4 is down again.”

“Wilted spinach and moldy berries in produce.”



STAGE 2 · COMPOSE

CO-STAR: the six parts of a strong prompt



C — Context

Who you are and the situation.



O — Objective

What you want it to do.



S — Style

How it should read — format, length.



T — Tone

The voice: warm, neutral, upbeat.



A — Audience

Who the answer is for.



R — Response

The exact output shape you want.



STAGE 2 · COMPOSE — CO-STAR APPLIED

The same ask, built with all six parts

Fill the six slots with what only you know — who you are, what you need, for whom, in what shape — and the answer transforms.

JUST ASKING

THE PROMPT

Summarize this feedback.

WHAT YOU GET BACK

Members had mixed feedback about their visit — some positive comments and some complaints. Overall it was a fairly typical weekend.

WHY IT FALLS SHORT

You gave it six words — no role, no reader, no shape to aim at. It hedged because guessing was all it could do.

COMPOSED WITH CO-STAR

THE PROMPT

Context: I'm in Member Care; below are ~30 survey comments. Objective: summarise for the club manager. Style: 5 short bullets. Tone: neutral. Audience: a busy manager. Response: themes with counts, safety first.

WHAT YOU GET BACK

- Safety: gas pump 4 down — 1.
- Checkout waits — 12.
- Produce quality — 7.
- Fresh food — 5 (+).
- App issues — 4.

WHY IT WORKS

Each slot handed over a fact only you knew — the batch, the reader, the shape — so nothing was left to guess.



STAGE 2 · COMPOSE — REFINE

Don't restart — improve in one follow-up

Got something close? Don't start over — nudge it in one follow-up and it keeps everything good.

FIRST TRY

THE PROMPT

Summarise this week's feedback in a short note to the manager.

WHAT YOU GET BACK

This week saw complaints about checkout waits and produce, plus praise for the fresh food. A few app and gas-pump issues too.

WHY IT FALLS SHORT

A first prompt rarely names everything you care about — you only see what's missing once you read an answer.

ONE REFINEMENT

THE PROMPT

Nice. Make it 5 bullets and put the safety issue first.

WHAT YOU GET BACK

- Safety: gas pump 4 down.
- Checkout waits — top complaint.
- Produce quality.
- App issues.
- Wins: fresh food.

WHY IT WORKS

The follow-up kept all the context you'd built and changed only what you named — far cheaper than starting over.



STAGE 3 · DIRECT — EXAMPLES

Show it, don't just tell it

Don't describe the format you want — show it. One or two done right, and it copies the pattern.

TOLD IT — “format these neatly”

THE PROMPT

Format these comments neatly.

WHAT YOU GET BACK

- checkout was really slow saturday, 3 lanes open

The rotisserie chicken is great, always fresh!

- app froze when I clipped the gas coupon

Gas pump 4 down again, ugh.

wilted spinach and moldy berries in produce

WHY IT FALLS SHORT

'Neatly' is a wish, not a format — with nothing to copy, it picked a different shape for every row.

SHOWED IT — two examples first

THE PROMPT

Here are two done right:

Checkout waits — Negative — 'slow.'

Rotisserie chicken — Positive — 'fresh.'

Now do the rest the same way.

WHAT YOU GET BACK

Checkout waits — Negative — 'only 3 lanes open.'

Rotisserie chicken — Positive — 'always fresh.'

App issues — Negative — 'froze on the gas coupon.'

Gas pump — Negative — 'pump 4 down again.'

Produce — Negative — 'wilted spinach, moldy berries.'

WHY IT WORKS

Two finished rows define the format better than a paragraph of rules — it simply continued the pattern it could see.



STAGE 3 · DIRECT — REASON FIRST

Ask for the reasoning before the answer

On judgment calls, tell it to weigh the factors out loud before it answers — the call gets sharper.

ANSWER FIRST

THE PROMPT

Which 3 issues should we escalate today?

WHAT YOU GET BACK

1. Checkout waits (most comments)
2. Produce quality
3. App issues

(Picks the most-repeated. The gas pump — a safety issue mentioned once — doesn't make the list.)

WHY IT FALLS SHORT

Answering instantly, it grabbed the loudest signal — repetition — because nothing told it what else to weigh.

REASON FIRST

THE PROMPT

...First reason through safety, how many members, and effort — then rank.

WHAT YOU GET BACK

Reasoning: pump 4 is a safety risk; checkout is the most-mentioned (12 of ~30); app issues are low-risk.

Rank: 1) Gas pump (safety) 2) Checkout waits (12) 3) App issues.

WHY IT WORKS

Naming the factors forced them into the decision: safety got weighed before volume, and the ranking shows its work.



STAGE 3 · DIRECT — STRUCTURE

Keep your instructions and your material apart

Label your instruction and your material separately, so the model never confuses the two.

ONE BIG BLOB

THE PROMPT

Group these into themes and count them. waited 22 min at checkout... chicken always fresh... pump 4 down... (+25 more)

WHAT YOU GET BACK

Sure — you'd like me to group and count these. The first few mention checkout waits and the rotisserie chicken, which sound positive overall...

WHY IT FALLS SHORT

With no boundary, your task and the comments blur into one wall of text — it can't tell orders from material.

CLEARLY LABELLED

THE PROMPT

*### TASK — group into themes, count each.
COMMENTS — (the 30 pasted below)*

WHAT YOU GET BACK

Checkout waits — 12
Produce quality — 7
Fresh food — 5
App issues — 4
Gas pump — 1

WHY IT WORKS

The labels draw the line: everything under TASK is instruction, everything under COMMENTS is data. Nothing leaks.



STAGE 3 · DIRECT — YOUR DOCUMENTS

Ground it in the source — and quote it

Give it the real source, tell it to answer only from that and quote — made-up facts drop sharply.

FROM MEMORY

THE PROMPT

What are this vendor's delivery terms?

WHAT YOU GET BACK

Typically 3–5 business days, with free returns within 30 days.

(None of this appears in the document.)

WHY IT FALLS SHORT

Asked from memory, it fills the gaps with plausible patterns — fluent, confident, and never checked against anything.

GROUNDED IN THE DOC

THE PROMPT

Using only the one-pager below, list the delivery terms. Quote each. Say 'not stated' if missing.

WHAT YOU GET BACK

- 'Orders ship within 10 business days.'
- 'Freight billed at cost.'
- Return window — not stated in the document.

WHY IT WORKS

'Only the document, quote it, or say not stated' leaves nowhere to invent — every line can be checked in seconds.



STAGE 3 · DIRECT — DIAGNOSE

When it misses, fix the prompt on purpose

When an output misses, name why — too vague? no counts? — and fix that one thing, don't re-roll.

FLAT SUMMARY

THE PROMPT

Summarize the feedback.

WHAT YOU GET BACK

Members had mixed feedback about their visit — some positive comments and some complaints. Overall it was a fairly typical weekend.

WHY IT FALLS SHORT

A vague ask re-rolled stays vague — the prompt, not luck, was the problem, so retrying changes nothing.

DIAGNOSED & FIXED

THE PROMPT

Too vague. Group by theme, count each, and give the top five.

WHAT YOU GET BACK

1. Checkout waits — 12
2. Produce quality — 7
3. Fresh food — 5 (+)
4. App issues — 4
5. Gas pump — 1 (safety)

WHY IT WORKS

You named the exact gap — themes, counts, a cap — and changed only that. One targeted fix beat five retries.



STAGE 4 · DESIGN — CHAIN

Break a big task into a chain of steps

Break a big job into small prompted steps, each feeding the next, so every step stays checkable.

ONE GIANT ASK

THE PROMPT

Summarize this week's feedback and tell me what to do.

WHAT YOU GET BACK

Members had varied feedback this week — some waits and product-quality issues, plus positives on the fresh food. You may want to look into staffing and freshness.

WHY IT FALLS SHORT

One prompt juggling tag, count, flag and draft spreads attention thin — the rare safety item is what gets dropped.

A CHAIN OF STEPS

THE PROMPT

Step 1: tag each (theme+sentiment). Step 2: count; flag safety. Step 3: draft 5 bullets from Step 2.

WHAT YOU GET BACK

Step 2 → Checkout 12, Produce 7, Food +5, App 4, Pump 1 (safety)

Step 3 → 'Safety: pump 4 — escalate. Checkout waits top volume...'

WHY IT WORKS

Each step does one job and hands checked work to the next — an error surfaces where it happened, not at the end.



STAGE 4 · DESIGN — TEMPLATES

Turn the winning prompt into a team tool

Once a prompt works, save it with blanks and a standing instruction so the whole team reuses it.

EVERYONE ROLLS THEIR OWN

THE PROMPT

(three managers, three different prompts)

WHAT YOU GET BACK

Club A: 'Lots of complaints about the lines.'

Club B: bullet list, no counts.

Club C: one paragraph, different order.

WHY IT FALLS SHORT

Eight people improvising means the quality lives in their heads — it varies by author and leaves when they do.

ONE SHARED TEMPLATE

THE PROMPT

System: always group, count, flag safety. Template: Summarise [SOURCE] for [CLUB], week of [DATE].

WHAT YOU GET BACK

Every club, same shape:

'Safety: pump 4. Checkout — 12. Produce — 7. App — 4. Fresh food +5.'

WHY IT WORKS

The standing instruction carries the standard; the blanks carry the week. One person's best prompt becomes the floor.



STAGE 4 · DESIGN — CONTEXT

With lots of material, more isn't better

More material isn't better — include what the task needs and cut the rest, so the signal stays sharp.

DUMP EVERYTHING

THE PROMPT

Summarize. (pastes 3 months of comments)

WHAT YOU GET BACK

Over the past quarter, feedback covered checkout, produce, the app, and gas — broadly consistent themes throughout.

WHY IT FALLS SHORT

Three months of noise drowned this week's signal — attention spread across everything means depth on nothing.

RIGHT-SIZED CONTEXT

THE PROMPT

Summarize this week's comments; compare to last week's counts (below).

WHAT YOU GET BACK

Checkout waits jumped 5 → 12 this week — a clear spike. Produce steady at 7. Suggest a look at weekend staffing.

WHY IT WORKS

This week plus one baseline is exactly enough to see change — the spike stands out once the noise is gone.



STAGE 4 · DESIGN — EVALUATE

Define “good,” then test two versions

Decide what “good” means up front, then run two versions on the same input and keep the winner.

“LOOKS FINE” — eyeball version A

THE PROMPT

(read it, looks good, ship it)

WHAT YOU GET BACK

Checkout waits — 10. Produce — 7. Good week overall.

(Count is off, and no safety flag.)

WHY IT FALLS SHORT

Reading for tone grades the writing, but the errors live in the facts — exactly where 'looks fine' never checks.

SCORED A/B

THE PROMPT

Good = correct counts · safety flagged · ≤5 bullets · plain language. Which meets all four?

WHAT YOU GET BACK

A: counts off, no safety → fails.

B: 'Pump 4 (safety); Checkout — 12...' → meets all four. Keep B.

WHY IT WORKS

Four written criteria turn 'seems good' into a checklist — B wins for reasons you can show, not a feeling.



STAGE 4 · DESIGN — GUARDRAILS

Build the checks in, not on

Build the checks into the prompt — ground it, cite or say “not sure,” and keep member data out.

UNGUARDED

THE PROMPT

Summarize and add some detail.

WHAT YOU GET BACK

Satisfaction was around 82%. Member Jane Smith complained pump 4 was down.

(Invented stat, and a member's name exposed.)

WHY IT FALLS SHORT

'Add detail' with no source is an instruction to invent — and a pasted name rides straight into the output.

GUARDRAILED

THE PROMPT

Use only the comments. Cite a quote or say 'not stated'. No member names.

WHAT YOU GET BACK

- Gas pump — 1 ('pump 4 down again'). Safety.
 - Satisfaction score — not stated.
- (No names included.)

WHY IT WORKS

Source-only, cite-or-say-not-stated, no names: the rules leave nothing to invent and nothing to leak.



THE WHOLE JOURNEY · ONE TASK

From a one-liner to a designed workflow

Every move stacks: compose it with CO-STAR, direct it, design it — one prompt that does the whole job.

JUST ASKING

THE PROMPT

Summarize this feedback.

WHAT YOU GET BACK

Members had mixed feedback this weekend — some good, some complaints.
Overall a typical weekend.

WHY IT FALLS SHORT

Six words in, guesswork out — this is the baseline every technique in this session just attacked.

COMPOSED · DIRECTED · DESIGNED

THE PROMPT

System: group by theme, count, flag safety, cite, ≤5 bullets. Summarise this week for [CLUB], then the top action.

WHAT YOU GET BACK

- Safety: pump 4 down — 1. Escalate today.
- Checkout waits — 12.
- Produce quality — 7.
- App issues — 4.
- Fresh food — 5 (+).

Top action: fix pump 4, add checkout staff.

WHY IT WORKS

Composed shape, directed grounding, designed reuse — every move adds a fact it needs or a check it must pass.



WHAT YOU CAN NOW DO · KEEP THIS CARD

Everything we promised, on one card

COMPOSE

CO-STAR

the six parts

Refine

improve in one follow-up

DIRECT

Examples

show, don't tell

Reason first

think, then answer

Structure

separate task & material

Your documents

ground & quote

Diagnose

name the flaw, fix it

DESIGN

Chain

small, checkable steps

Templates

save it, share it

Context

include what helps

Evaluate

define good, A/B

Guardrails

ground, cite, protect data

YOU'VE SEEN THE WHOLE JOURNEY

Asking → Composing → Directing → Designing

Twelve moves, one habit: tell the model what only you know — clearly, and safely. Pick one move and use it on a real task Monday — then go deeper with the full Beginner, Intermediate, and Advanced modules.